

« The social media follower count can go up and down, but my achievements should not »

# NAVDEEP SINGH

Someone told me recently that I'm the second most-followed Indian para-athlete on Instagram, with around 220,000 followers. It doesn't feel real to me because just a year ago, I had only about 10,000. It's strange when people say they wait to see what I'm posting.

All of that changed after the 2024 Paralympics, where I won gold in F41 Javelin. My social media went *pagal* (crazy). I got caught up in it too — thinking about what video to post next, what stories to share, checking who was following me, and whether someone famous had started following me.

Despite all the progress I had made, I never expected to throw 46 metres [the second throw was a then Personal Best of 46.39m] and win gold in Paris. The Chinese athlete had reached 48 metres, and the Iranian was throwing around 47. Realistically, I should have been aiming for bronze. But things happened differently. Suddenly, I was in silver position, and then I moved to gold. Even now, it's hard to

believe. People still remind me of how I shouted all those gaalis (abuses) after the win; it's embarrassing. I really hope that if I win gold in New Delhi, I manage my emotions better, at least away from the TV cameras!

Even now, updates go up on my *Instagram* every few days, but I don't handle them anymore. I deleted the app from my phone three months ago and handed over my account to someone else. My reason is simple: I have a big target ahead — the Para Athletics World Championships in Delhi. This is the biggest competition for me since the Paris Olympics, and I want to give it my full focus.

I'm waiting for the medal designs

of the Worlds to be released, because I plan to keep a picture of that medal as my phone wallpaper for motivation. Apart from gold, there's another number always in my mind: 47.32m. That's what I threw to win in Paris. I want to go beyond that. I may be a Paralympic champion, but in New Delhi, I want to achieve a Personal Best.

Right now, I'm training at SAI, Gandhinagar. I have a bad habit where my left arm drops too much during the throw, and I'm working hard to correct it. I'm aiming for technical perfection so that I don't make mistakes on the big day. I want that day to be truly special.

This year has already brought big



**Life has changed a lot since Paris. Para-athletes are finally getting the recognition we never had before. Para sport is being promoted, and athletes like me, once treated as a joke, are now celebrated.**